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Growth Circle Weekly Heavy Machinery Networking Meeting — Audit-Defensible Minutes

Date: Friday, March 20, 2026 (start time 7:00 AM) **Format:** Live group video call, approximately 25 attendees (Growth Circle members) **Duration:** Not specified in source notes; typical Friday session length **Facilitator:** Ben (organizer of the weekly Friday Growth Circle sessions; coordinator of the Liberty FCU briefing for the group) **Featured guest:** Andy Martin — VP Commercial Lending, Liberty Federal Credit Union; primary lender contact for the Growth Circle’s Heavy Machinery / Equipment Share / EZ “own program” loan originations **Named participants:** Ben, Andy Martin (Liberty FCU), Derek (originally surfaced the Liberty relationship in July 2025), Sunil (visited the box house manufacturing facility in person), plus additional Growth Circle members who contributed questions and commentary throughout. The source notes do not provide a full attendee roster. **Recording status:** Not specified in source notes. **Distributed materials:** None specified during the meeting; reference materials cited but not distributed (e.g., the Equipment Share post-IPO public financial statements available through standard public-company channels).

Meeting overview

The Friday, March 20, 2026 Growth Circle Weekly Heavy Machinery Networking Meeting brought Andy Martin from Liberty Federal Credit Union onto the call as the featured guest, after Ben had been organizing the session for approximately three weeks. The purpose was to give the Growth Circle community — both returning 2025 participants and members new to the program — a comprehensive briefing on the Equipment Share / EZ Equipment Zone “own program” from the perspective of the lender that originated approximately 40% of the program’s total 2025 loan volume.

The session covered Liberty’s institutional profile, the program’s four-party ownership and cash flow structure, current program economics (with a candid acknowledgment of compressed returns), Liberty’s three-test underwriting framework, refinancing and repeat-investment mechanics, the implications of Equipment Share’s recent IPO, the importance of early-in-the-year entry, the platform fee and facilitator fee structure, the 2025 performance issues with Bevel as a financing intermediary, downside-protection planning for a worst-case scenario, and — as a substantial

sidebar — a comprehensive group discussion of Braden’s pitch of the “box house” program as the alternative tax-mitigation strategy for 2026.

The overarching theme was structural understanding: a returning participant or new entrant needs to know who the parties are, what the cash flows look like in detail, what the underwriting bar is, where the fees go, and what happens if something goes wrong. The Heavy Machinery program is the operative tax-strategy track for most members on the call; the box house comparison surfaced as a way for the group to evaluate whether the alternative was viable or whether Heavy Machinery remained the better path. By the end of the discussion, the group’s working consensus was that Heavy Machinery — despite the compression in cash-on-cash returns — remained the more structurally defensible 2026 strategy.

1. Liberty Federal Credit Union — institutional profile

Andy opened with Liberty’s institutional context. Liberty is a federally chartered credit union with **approximately \$4.5 billion in total assets** — a mid-sized but substantial institution. The figure was provided to frame Liberty’s credibility and scale: large enough to carry meaningful institutional relationships and lending capacity, focused enough to be deeply engaged with the Equipment Share program’s specific mechanics.

Liberty entered the Equipment Share / EZ “own program” approximately three years ago, after being introduced by one of the very first lenders in the program. Andy emphasized that Liberty came in with institutional backing and early-mover knowledge rather than as a latecomer learning on the fly. Over the course of their involvement, Liberty has visited Equipment Share’s headquarters, met with the Bevel team and the EZ team, and engaged with Equipment Share leadership multiple times. Andy described Liberty’s team as having become “very comfortable” with the residual values of the underlying equipment, the cash flow mechanics of the rental income, and the full document and servicing workflow.

Origination volume context: Liberty originated approximately **\$150 million** in equipment rental loans in 2024 (their second year in the program). In 2025, that figure grew to **over \$400 million**, representing roughly **40% of EZ’s total program origination volume** for the year. For 2026, Andy stated Liberty is planning to originate even more, and that despite a typically slower first quarter, they are already ahead of where they were at the same point last year.

A critical structural differentiator: **Liberty carries no prepayment penalties** on any of their loans in this program. Andy noted that most other lenders participating in the program do impose prepayment penalties, which effectively locks borrowers in for the duration of their loan term. Liberty’s no-prepay policy gives investors flexibility — they can refinance if rates move meaningfully, or simply stay with Liberty knowing they have optionality.

Andy reported that Liberty has had **zero delinquencies and zero charge-offs** across their entire book of equipment rental loans in this program to date. He attributed this largely to the automated payment structure — rents come in around the 20th of each month, loan payments go out around the 26th, leaving no room for human error or missed payments.

2. Program structure — the four parties and the cash flow chain

Andy walked through the program’s ownership and cash flow chain in detail. The structure involves four distinct parties:

Equipment Share is the operating company at the top of the chain — a large publicly traded equipment rental business (boom lifts, scissor lifts, heavy construction and industrial equipment). Equipment Share owns and operates the equipment fleet and generates revenue by renting it out to contractors and construction companies.

Easy Equipment Zone (EZ) is a privately held company that sits between Equipment Share and investors. EZ purchases tranches of equipment from Equipment Share and resells that equipment to individual investors through the “own program.” EZ also manages the rental income flow — collecting rent from Equipment Share and distributing it to investors. Investors sign contracts with EZ, so EZ’s financial health and operational reliability most directly affect whether investors receive their monthly rental payments. Andy noted that EZ is potentially one of Liberty’s largest customers even outside of this program, and that their financials would “check out to any investor” who did due diligence.

Investors (Growth Circle members) purchase the equipment from EZ, typically financing 90% of the purchase price through Liberty and putting 10% down themselves. The investor legally owns the equipment for the duration of the contract. The equipment is then leased back to Equipment Share via EZ, generating monthly rental income that flows back to the investor’s Liberty account.

Liberty Federal Credit Union finances the 90% loan, services the debt, and manages the automated payment flow. Once all funds (investor down payment plus Liberty loan proceeds) are received by EZ, the investor begins earning rental income. The loan term is **10 years**; the rental contract with EZ is **6 years**, at the end of which EZ buys the equipment back from the investor at the **hurdle rate** (currently 56% of the original purchase price). The investor then uses the buyback proceeds to continue paying down the remaining loan balance over the final 4 years, or refinances or pays off the loan at that point.

Monthly cash flow timing: rental income auto-deposits into the investor’s Liberty account around the 20th; the loan payment auto-debits around the 26th. This tight, automated cycle is why Liberty has experienced no delinquencies.

3. Current program economics — compressed returns, tax-strategy primary thesis

Andy was transparent about a material shift in program economics over the past 12-18 months. The primary driver has been a steady compression in the monthly rental income that Equipment Share pays to EZ and that EZ passes through to investors.

Return on down payment has fallen from approximately **18% at the program’s peak** to approximately **5% currently**. The group acknowledged this as a dramatic reduction. The context Andy provided: the vast majority of participants are in the program primarily for **bonus depreciation tax offsets**, not for yield. The equipment purchase generates a large first-year depreciation deduction that offsets other income, making the investment valuable even at a 5% cash-on-cash return on the down payment.

Monthly rental income is currently approximately **\$11,050 per \$1 million of equipment value**, down from approximately \$11,200 at the end of 2025 and from \$11,400-\$11,450 earlier in 2025. The trend is clearly downward, though Andy noted Equipment Share’s improving financials (now publicly visible post-IPO) provide some comfort that the company can sustain even these lower payments.

The hurdle rate — the percentage of original purchase price at which EZ commits to buying back the equipment after 6 years — remains at **56%**. Andy confirmed this directly with **Kyle Christian, head of finance at EZ**, just before joining the call. He emphasized this is the current rate as of the meeting and could change in future tranches, but is unchanged from last year.

Liberty’s interest rate on most current deals is **7.25%**. For deals over \$1 million involving highly creditworthy borrowers, Liberty can go as low as **7.00%**. Andy explained why rates on this program are higher than what investors might expect from conventional commercial loans: the loan-to-value ratio is 90% (versus a typical 75-80% for commercial real estate), and the term is 10 years (versus 5-7 years typical for equipment loans). These structural differences justify the rate premium relative to, for example, an apartment-complex loan.

Origination fee is **1.25%** at Liberty. Andy was direct that this fee does not change for repeat customers — Liberty's volume is high enough that they don't need to discount to retain business. He framed this matter-of-factly rather than apologetically.

Cash flow illustration (Andy's rough estimate). At 7.25% on a \$1 million loan with \$11,050/month in rental income, Andy estimated investors are making approximately \$200/month positive spread — explicitly described as a rough, off-the-cuff figure. At 8% (the rate some members locked in last year through other lenders), cash flow approaches breakeven or goes slightly negative, which is why several members on the call were exploring refinancing options.

4. Liberty's underwriting criteria — three sequential tests

Andy framed Liberty's underwriting in terms of three sequential tests that every borrower must pass:

Test 1 — Debt service coverage without rental income. This is the primary and most important criterion. Liberty wants to know: if Equipment Share stopped making rental payments tomorrow, could the investor still make their loan payment from their own income and cash flow? This is a conservative stress test that treats the rental income as a bonus rather than a necessity. Andy's example: on a \$500,000 equipment purchase with a \$450,000 loan, the annual payment is approximately \$50,000; the borrower needs to demonstrate at least \$50,000 in excess annual cash flow from sources other than the rental income. This test is what makes the program accessible primarily to higher-income investors.

Test 2 — Credit score. Liberty looks for a minimum FICO score of approximately **720**. The average credit score across Liberty's program book is **780**, suggesting the typical participant is well above the minimum threshold.

Test 3 — Post-down-payment liquidity. After the 10% down payment, the borrower must have a meaningful cushion of liquid assets remaining. Andy was careful to note there is no fixed dollar amount — the threshold is evaluated relative to the borrower's total debt load, contingent liabilities, and overall financial picture. Liberty wants a comfortable buffer, not a razor-thin margin.

Additional considerations:

- **Used equipment.** Liberty caps used equipment at no more than 10% of any given schedule. They have done a small number of all-used deals (two or three total), priced at 7.75–8% to reflect the higher risk profile. Andy's strong preference is for new equipment, which has better-defined residual values and lower depreciation uncertainty.
- **Borrowing entity.** Liberty needs to know the ownership structure of the borrowing entity, but the exact entity does not need to be finalized at initial approval. This gives investors flexibility to set up their LLC or trust in parallel with the underwriting process.

Pre-qualification process. Andy emphasized that a simple **5-minute phone call with no documents required** can give a borrower a solid ballpark on borrowing capacity. He compared it to a mortgage pre-approval based on stated information.

Full documentation required for underwriting:

1. Last 2 years of personal and/or business tax returns, including all K-1s
 2. Liquidity verification for non-retirement accounts (retirement accounts excluded because they are not freely accessible)
 3. Personal financial statement listing all assets and liabilities, current within the past 12 months (Liberty's form or another institution's form acceptable)
 4. Borrowing entity details and ownership breakdown
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5. Refinancing, rate flexibility, and repeat investments

Several members asked about refinancing existing loans and the economics of repeat investments. Andy's responses:

Refinancing existing Liberty loans. Liberty does not proactively reprice loans for small rate movements. For drops of 0.25-0.50%, Liberty will not automatically offer to lower the rate; conversely, if rates rise, they won't ask for a higher rate either. Liberty views the relationship as a two-way commitment. For rate differences of approximately **0.75-1.00% or more**, Liberty would engage in a refinancing conversation. Andy's framing: "What would it cost you to go somewhere else?" — if the savings are meaningful, they'll talk.

Refinancing loans at other lenders. For members who financed through other lenders (often via Bevel) and are now sitting at rates like 8%, the path to refinancing depends entirely on whether the promissory note contains a prepayment penalty. Andy's advice: pull out the promissory note and read the prepayment penalty language carefully. If there is no prepay, refinancing is straightforward. If there is a prepay, you are likely locked in for the duration of the term, making refinancing economically unattractive.

Repeat investments. Andy estimated over 50% of year-one investors come back for a second investment. The second-time process is significantly faster — Liberty already has the borrower's financial profile in their system. Andy described it as roughly half the time of the first underwriting; fewer documents to gather from scratch.

Stacking multiple investments. One member asked about limits on how many times a borrower could be approved. Andy's answer: entirely case-by-case, driven by the same three underwriting tests. As the cumulative debt grows, the debt service coverage test becomes increasingly demanding, which is the natural limiting factor.

Grouping or consolidating loans. Ben asked whether multiple loans could be grouped together and refinanced as a single facility. Andy confirmed this is possible in principle but would be evaluated on its own merits. He noted that the terms on these loans are inherently different from conventional commercial loans — part of why the rates are where they are — and any consolidation would need to reflect that.

6. Equipment Share IPO — full implications

One of the most significant developments since the prior year's program is that Equipment Share went public approximately **6-8 weeks before this meeting**. Andy spoke to the implications from both a lender and investor perspective.

Positive implications:

- Equipment Share's financials are now publicly available, including their bond rating and cash flow statements. Any investor can look them up and evaluate the company's financial health independently.
- Andy reported that Equipment Share's financials are improving — they are cash-flow positive and meet all of Liberty's lending metrics. Equipment Share is potentially one of Liberty's largest customers even outside the own program.
- The public-company structure provides greater transparency and accountability than a private company, which increases lender comfort.

Risk implications:

- Public companies face quarterly earnings pressure from Wall Street. This creates an ongoing incentive for Equipment Share to maximize profits, which in practice can mean continuing to push rental rates paid to investors lower over time.

- One member raised this concern explicitly: as Equipment Share tries to show better numbers every quarter, is there a risk that program terms get progressively worse for investors? Andy acknowledged this is a real dynamic but offered a counterpoint.

Andy's counterpoint — the program is structurally important to Equipment Share. Andy argued that the own program is not a peripheral feature for Equipment Share but a core part of their business model, explicitly referenced in their prospectus. The program allows Equipment Share to take equipment debt off their balance sheet, which in turn supports a **\$2 billion+ borrowing facility** that Equipment Share relies on to fund growth. Without the own program, Equipment Share would have significantly less borrowing capacity. This structural dependency means Equipment Share has a strong incentive to keep the program attractive enough to continue drawing investor capital.

The floor on rent compression. Andy was clear that there is a hard economic floor below which Equipment Share cannot push rental rates. If monthly rent drops to the point where investors are cash-flow negative — having to come out of pocket each month — the program loses its appeal and investor participation dries up. Equipment Share needs the program, so they need to keep it at least cash-flow neutral for investors. Andy does not expect rents to go negative, though he acknowledged they will likely continue to drift lower as Equipment Share optimizes its cost structure.

7. Tranche dynamics and why early entry matters

A recurring theme throughout the call was the importance of entering the program early in the calendar year. Andy and other experienced members offered several reasons:

Tranche renegotiation. EZ and Equipment Share negotiate the terms of each new equipment tranche — including rental rates — every time a new batch of equipment is purchased. This can happen multiple times per year. Once an investor locks into a specific tranche, their rental rate is **fixed for the full 6-year term** of their contract. Entering early in the year when terms are more favorable locks in those terms permanently; waiting through deteriorating tranches means being stuck with worse terms for 6 years.

Equipment quality. Earlier in the year, EZ is selling brand-new, current model-year equipment. As the year progresses, some older (one- or two-year-old) equipment gets mixed in. Liberty caps used equipment at 10% of any schedule, and newer equipment has better-defined residual values and lower risk.

Processing speed. Liberty processed deals in approximately **1-2 weeks during the first three quarters of the year**. In the final two months of 2025, processing times stretched to approximately one month due to the volume surge — Liberty did roughly 85% of its annual volume in the last four months of the year. Other lenders experienced even longer delays.

Tax year timing. If an investor invests late in the year and does not receive a first rental payment until January, no 1099 is issued for the current tax year. One member on the call noted this happened to them — invested late and could not get the 1099 in time. Entering early ensures the investment is fully operational within the current tax year.

Institutional capacity. Lenders' "boxes" fill up as the year progresses. Some investors who wait too long may find their preferred lender at capacity and either turned away or slow-walked.

8. Platform fees, the facilitator-fee structure, and the 2026 question

A significant portion of the group discussion focused on the fee landscape and whether it can be simplified for 2026. This area surfaced genuine uncertainty among members about exactly how the economics flow.

The EZ platform fee (3%). When an investor participates in the own program, they pay a platform fee to EZ of approximately 3% of the investment amount, paid on each new investment including repeat investments. Andy confirmed that an investor cannot get their equipment list (the specific assets assigned to the investment) without paying the platform fee. The fee covers EZ's operational costs for setting up the program infrastructure, managing equipment assignments, and administering the rental income flow.

The facilitator fee (1%). Historically, there has been an additional 1% fee associated with **Michael**, who served as the educational and organizational layer connecting Growth Circle members to the EZ program. Michael also brought Bevel into the picture as the financing intermediary. The 1% appears to flow from EZ's platform-fee economics — EZ pays Michael out of the platform fee for bringing investors to the program, and Michael in turn pays **Braden** a portion for bringing his Growth Circle members.

Mid-meeting clarification — investors do not pay the facilitator fee separately. One member noted that when they met with the owner of EZ directly, the owner was explicit that investors do not pay the facilitator fee separately — it comes out of the platform fee. This suggests the 1% to Michael is not an additional out-of-pocket cost but rather a portion of the 3% platform fee that gets allocated to the facilitator layer. *(Recorded as a correction to the conventional framing because the clarification meaningfully changes how members should understand the fee stack.)*

The 2026 question. Several participants argued that given how much education and infrastructure now exists within Growth Circle — years of Friday calls, detailed meeting notes, Andy's direct contact information, members' own experience — Michael's 1% facilitator layer may no longer be necessary or justified. If Braden can negotiate directly with EZ to remove or reduce this layer, it could meaningfully reduce the total cost of participation. **Ben indicated he would raise this with Braden.**

Braden's role and incentive. One member's framing: Braden's goal is to make the heavy equipment program as viable and cost-effective as possible — because the more attractive the tax strategies he offers, the more reason members have to stay in Growth Circle. Negotiating down fees is therefore directly aligned with his business interests as well as members' financial interests.

9. Bevel — history, problems, and 2026 outlook

Bevel is a financing intermediary that EZ uses to connect investors with lenders. Bevel does not originate loans itself; it acts as a routing and coordination layer between EZ and the various banks and credit unions that fund the loans.

2025 performance. Members widely criticized Bevel's performance in 2025, describing the experience as slow, frustrating, and error-prone — particularly during the high-volume final months of the year. The consensus framing was that Bevel "hurt the process rather than helped." This was contrasted with working directly with Liberty, which members described as fast, smooth, and straightforward.

Andy's nuance. Andy offered that Bevel has been in the program for a while and has established relationships. The difficulty in 2025 was partly a function of the end-of-year volume surge — anyone processing loans in November and December was going to experience delays regardless of Bevel's involvement. Andy suggested that going through any lender in the first eight months of the year would be a significantly better experience than what people encountered at year-end.

For members currently with Bevel-routed lenders who want to switch to Liberty for 2026: Andy's advice was to push EZ directly and explicitly. EZ's default behavior is to route members back to their prior lender — if a borrower does not actively request a change, EZ will assume they want to stay where they are. A clear, strong case for switching can be accommodated. The caveat: if a member went through Bevel and the current lender has a prepayment penalty, they are likely stuck with that lender for the existing loan even if they can switch for the new 2026 investment.

Several members speculated that Bevel may be phased out of the program entirely given its 2025 performance. Andy neither confirmed nor denied this but acknowledged the sentiment.

10. Downside protection — Liberty’s institutional planning

Andy addressed the worst-case-scenario question: what happens if Equipment Share fails or stops making rental payments to EZ, and EZ in turn stops paying investors?

Most likely scenario. Andy’s strong belief is that if Equipment Share ran into serious trouble, one of the other major equipment rental companies in the country would step in to acquire them or purchase a portion of their fleet. Equipment Share is a large, established player with significant assets, and the equipment itself (boom lifts, scissor lifts, etc.) has well-established secondary market value. A distressed acquisition by a competitor is far more likely than a disorderly liquidation.

If liquidation becomes necessary. Liberty has already done significant preparatory work on this front. They identified a large national equipment liquidation company that specializes in exactly this type of asset; Andy could not recall the firm’s name on the call but noted it was featured in a recent Liberty board presentation. Liberty has approximately **\$550 million in this program across roughly 500 borrowers**, which gives them meaningful scale and leverage when approaching a liquidation firm. Liberty would not leave individual investors to navigate this alone — they would organize a coordinated process, present the liquidation option to all affected customers, and provide the framework (company, rates, process) for those who want to proceed.

Why this matters relative to alternative programs. Andy implicitly contrasted this with the box house program (discussed in Section 11), where the exit strategy is far murkier. With heavy equipment, there is a proven secondary market, Liberty has done the institutional homework, and the residual value of the underlying assets is well-established globally — including demand from markets like China and India. With box house units, the exit involves selling a modular structure that may have planned-obsolescence issues and a limited buyer pool.

11. Box house program — comprehensive group discussion

A substantial portion of the meeting addressed the box house (“box office”) program that Braden has been presenting as the primary 2026 tax-mitigation strategy. The discussion was extensive enough to warrant its own structured walkthrough.

11.1 What the program is

The box house is a modular, prefabricated housing investment manufactured by a company whose facility **Sunil visited in person** prior to the call. The product is a relocatable structure — designed to be assembled, disassembled, moved, and reassembled. The manufacturer has reportedly stress-tested the units by breaking them down and reassembling them **30 times**, on the theory that a unit would never be moved that many times in real-world use. Units are designed to be deployed in clusters to create community or campus-style arrangements.

Sunil’s first-hand impressions, shared with the group: he described the product as “a pretty cool thing” and said he could see himself living in one. The solar component drew praise — a single solar pad was demonstrated to be capable of powering four units simultaneously, which several members found impressive.

11.2 Investment structure differences from heavy machinery

- **Lower minimum investment.** Heavy machinery typically starts at \$280,000-\$400,000+; box house has a lower entry point. Some members on the call suggested this is why Braden may have positioned box house as the top 2026 strategy — it opens the program to Growth Circle members who do not have the liquidity or income to qualify for a heavy equipment loan at Liberty.
- **No credit-report impact.** One member explicitly noted that the box house investment does not show up on a personal credit report, unlike heavy equipment loans which are personal/entity loans that do appear. For members concerned about debt-to-income ratio or credit profile for other financing purposes, this is a meaningful structural difference.
- **Co-ownership and entity structure.** The investment involves LLC and/or trust ownership structures, with multiple investors potentially co-owning individual units. The group flagged co-ownership as a significant complication, particularly around exit — fractional ownership through a trust means a single investor cannot unilaterally sell, move, or liquidate. All co-owners must agree.
- **Tax strategy basis.** Like heavy equipment, the primary appeal is bonus depreciation — a large first-year depreciation deduction on the unit purchase price offsetting other taxable income. The investment is not primarily a yield play; it is a tax mitigation tool.
- **Deadline and allocation structure.** The program had a specific enrollment deadline of the following Tuesday (two days after the March 20 meeting). Braden had structured a group allocation where if Growth Circle collectively committed to **500 units**, a second tranche would be made available later in 2026 (reportedly in July). As of the call, sign-ups were **below 300 units** — well short of the 500-unit threshold — making the second allocation unlikely to materialize.

11.3 Braden's positioning — why box house first

Several members expressed surprise or disagreement with Braden's decision to position box house as the top 2026 strategy ahead of heavy equipment. The group surfaced multiple theories without resolving which was operative:

- **Braden's own underwriting.** Braden had reportedly done a detailed comparative analysis of the two programs (framing box house as "workforce housing") and concluded workforce housing was the "clear winner." Most members on the call disagreed with that conclusion but acknowledged it was Braden's genuine analytical view, not arbitrary.
- **Cash-flow argument.** Part of Braden's rationale appears to be the cash-flowing nature of box house — units generate rental income (particularly in workforce, deployment, or senior-living contexts) — which Braden may have modeled as more attractive than the compressed returns now available in heavy equipment.
- **Accessibility.** The lower minimum investment opens box house to a wider slice of Growth Circle members.
- **Fee-and-relationship dynamics.** Some members speculated that Braden's ordering may also reflect fee economics — Michael's facilitator layer in heavy equipment is increasingly being questioned, which may complicate Braden's economics from that program. Box house may represent a cleaner fee structure for Braden.

11.4 Concerns raised by members — substantive reservations

The group surfaced significant concerns, several of which led members to pass on the investment entirely.

A — Price per square foot. Multiple members raised the issue of cost per square foot relative to conventional construction. One member's blunt characterization: "The prices for square foot is unbelievable." The premium exists because the price reflects not just the structure but the mobility and relocatability — engineering and manufacturing for assembly, disassembly, and re-deployment. The concern: if an investor is not actually planning to move the unit — if it is simply

being placed at a fixed senior-living or workforce-housing site — they are paying a significant premium for a feature they will never use. In that scenario, conventional modular or stick-built construction would be dramatically cheaper per square foot.

B — Planned obsolescence (“the car model” problem). One member described a conversation with the box house company’s sales representative, during which the rep showed them older models (3-year-old, 4-year-old units) alongside the current model. The implication: the product is evolving year over year, with each new model meaningfully better than the last. The member’s reaction was that the product is “like a car” — buying a 2026 model today means by 2028 there will be a 2028 model that is superior, and the 2026 unit will be functionally obsolete. This planned-obsolescence dynamic is particularly problematic for the roll-up exit strategy (below), where the value of the investment depends on the units being attractive to a future acquirer.

C — Limited storage and living space. One member raised the issue of closet and storage space within the units. For workforce or temporary deployment housing (e.g., construction workers at a remote job site), limited space is acceptable. However, Braden’s pitch includes a roll-up exit strategy positioning the units as semi-permanent housing for families or longer-term residents, in which context lack of storage becomes a quality-of-life issue limiting the pool of potential long-term tenants or buyers.

D — Exit strategy (the core problem). This was the most fundamental concern. The roll-up strategy Braden has pitched works as follows: at some future point, a larger company or REIT acquires the portfolio of box house units from investors, paying a premium that generates a meaningful return — the “gold mine” scenario. Members identified multiple problems:

- *Speculative.* The roll-up depends on a future acquirer materializing at a price and time that work. None of these variables are guaranteed.
- *Not everyone gets in.* Even if a roll-up does occur, Braden has approximately 300 investors in the program. A roll-up acquirer will be selective — they will not take every unit from every investor. One member’s framing: it is a “lottery that some will win and others won’t.”
- *Co-ownership governance.* Fractional ownership through a trust with other investors means no unilateral exit. All co-owners must agree. With potentially dozens of co-owners across hundreds of units, coordinating a collective exit is logistically and legally complex.
- *No proven secondary market.* Unlike heavy equipment, which has a well-established global secondary market with known buyers in markets like China and India, box house units do not have a comparable liquid market. If the roll-up does not happen, the question of who an investor sells to is unclear, and planned obsolescence makes finding a buyer for an older unit harder.
- *Contrast with heavy equipment.* Several members explicitly contrasted the two exits. With heavy equipment, Liberty has already identified a national liquidation company, presented to their board, and has a coordinated plan ready. Residual value of boom lifts is proven and global. With box house, there is no equivalent institutional backstop — one member’s characterization: “an expensive mobile home.”

E — Uncertainty profile relative to heavy equipment. One member articulated the overall concern: “With box house, you’ve got a lot of assumptions. With heavy equipment, you’ve got a lot more certainty.” Heavy equipment has a publicly traded counterparty (Equipment Share), a known operating company (EZ), a lender with institutional downside planning, a proven secondary market, fixed contractual rental income, and a defined buyback mechanism. Box house has an evolving product line, a speculative roll-up, co-ownership governance complexity, no proven secondary market, planned-obsolescence risk, and a high price per square foot.

11.5 Positive aspects acknowledged

The discussion was not entirely negative. Several positive attributes were noted:

- The product itself is genuinely innovative; Sunil’s first-hand impression after visiting the facility was favorable.

- The solar component is impressive — a single pad powering four units is a meaningful energy-efficiency feature.
- No credit-report impact is a real structural advantage for some investors.
- The lower entry point opens the program to members who cannot qualify for heavy-equipment financing.
- The cluster/community potential — assembling units into senior-living or workforce-housing campuses — is a genuinely interesting use case.
- For temporary workforce-housing (construction sites, remote deployments), the product makes practical sense and the limited storage space is not a problem.

11.6 Member decisions reached during the meeting

By the end of the discussion, sentiment had shifted away from the box house program for most participants. One member explicitly stated they would not be participating. Several others expressed similar skepticism. The group's collective working view was that heavy equipment — despite compressed returns — remains the more reliable, better-structured, and more defensible tax strategy for 2026, particularly given Liberty's institutional involvement and the proven exit mechanics.

11.7 Key unresolved questions

The call left several important questions unanswered regarding the box house program:

- What exactly are the tax mechanics — is it bonus depreciation, and if so, on what depreciable basis?
- What is the specific rental yield on the units, and who are the tenants (workforce housing operators, senior living facilities, individual renters)?
- What are the exact terms of the co-ownership structure — how many investors per unit, how are decisions made, what are the governance rules?
- Is there any contractual exit mechanism beyond the speculative roll-up, and if so, what are the terms?
- How does the manufacturer address the planned-obsolescence concern — is there any upgrade or trade-in program?
- What happens to the investment if the manufacturer itself runs into financial difficulty?

These unanswered questions, combined with the substantive concerns raised, appeared sufficient for most members to pass on the Tuesday deadline.

Action items and open follow-ups

Action items with identified owner or trigger:

- **Ben to raise the 1% facilitator-fee question with Braden.** Specifically, whether the Michael layer can be removed or reduced for the 2026 cohort given the maturity of Growth Circle's own educational and organizational infrastructure.
- **Members currently financed through Bevel-routed lenders** should pull their promissory notes and read the prepayment-penalty language carefully before deciding whether to refinance to Liberty.
- **Members wanting to switch from a Bevel-routed lender to Liberty for 2026** need to push EZ directly and explicitly to make the change; EZ's default is to route back to the prior lender unless the borrower actively requests otherwise.

Open structural questions raised but not resolved in this meeting:

- Will Bevel continue in the 2026 program or be phased out? Andy did not confirm or deny.
- Can the platform fee be negotiated for repeat investors who are not using the facilitator layer? The conversation between Braden and EZ should clarify this.

- The box house program’s enrollment deadline is the Tuesday following this meeting; the 500-unit threshold for a second tranche appears unlikely to be met. Whether Braden will run an additional cohort regardless was not resolved.

Pre-qualification path for new entrants: Andy’s 5-minute no-document phone call is the recommended low-friction entry point for any member considering the program for the first time or evaluating a second investment.

Material participation relevance

This meeting carries mixed material-participation implications under IRC §469 / Treas. Reg. §1.469-5T(a), depending on the attending investor’s posture toward the program. The minutes describe content categories generically; any specific investor’s classification, duration claim, and hour-budget impact belong in that investor’s own downstream journal entry, not in this shared evidence file.

Content that supports material participation (Test 3 qualifying for active program participants who attend with an entity-specific operational stake): Liberty’s underwriting framework discussion as it relates to one’s own LLC and loan structure; the program’s four-party cash flow chain as it bears on the investor’s own equipment-ownership posture; current program economics as inputs to one’s own multi-year tax modeling; the prepayment-penalty / refinancing analysis as it bears on one’s own existing loan if any; the Equipment Share IPO implications for the operational risk profile of one’s own equipment-rental stream; and the platform-fee / facilitator-fee discussion as it bears on one’s own structural cost basis.

Content that does not support material participation for investors attending in an exploratory capacity (considering rather than already operating in the program) — the §1.469-5T(f)(2)(ii) investor-capacity disqualifier likely applies to the general-program-orientation segments.

Pre-formation timing consideration. Investors whose LLC formation date postdates this meeting should be aware that the pre_form disqualifier under §1.469-5T may apply to time logged for attending this meeting, separate from the substantive-content classification question. This is a matter for each attendee’s individual documentation discipline and is not adjudicated here.

The mixed-meeting principle: most weekly networking meetings combine multiple content types. Each attending investor needs to draw the apportionment line in their own journal entry, with reference to the segment-by-segment breakdown the minutes provide.

Cross-references

- This is the third Friday Growth Circle Weekly Heavy Machinery Networking Meeting captured in the audit-defensible meeting-minutes corpus, after the May 15, 2026 meeting (the Brayden Miller financial-model walkthrough) and the foundational 2025 Friday-call series that preceded the formal documentation discipline.
- The 2025 Bevel performance issues referenced throughout this March 20 discussion are background context for the operational improvements that came with switching to direct Liberty engagement during the 2026 program cycle.
- Andy Martin’s underwriting framework here is the published lender posture that downstream Liberty loan-application work is calibrated against; investors preparing loan packages should treat these three tests as the canonical underwriting filter.
- Kyle Christian (head of finance at EZ) was cited by Andy as having confirmed the 56% hurdle rate immediately before this call; he is the appropriate point of contact at EZ for hurdle-rate questions.

Data integrity statement

These minutes were authored on May 17, 2026 in a Cowork session, using as source material the draft meeting summary preserved at uploads/2026-03-20-Liberty-FCU__joss-renaud.-DRAFT_MTG_NOTES.pdf. The source notes were themselves a working reconstruction of the March 20, 2026 meeting and are not a verbatim transcript. If the meeting recording exists and is consulted later, it controls over any factual conflict with these minutes.

Named attributions in these minutes are taken from the source material. Where the source identifies a participant only by first name (e.g., Ben, Sunil, Derek), last names have not been guessed. The name **Braden** appears in this source referring to the Growth Circle organizational layer that connects members to the EZ program; readers of the broader minutes corpus should note that a separate individual named **Brayden Miller** appears in the May 15, 2026 minutes as the accountant who presented the financial modeling spreadsheet at that meeting, and these are understood to be two different individuals despite the similar names. The March 20 source spelling of “Braden” (without the ‘y’) is preserved here verbatim; any later confirmation of a correct standardized spelling would warrant a Correction entry.

The minutes were de-personalized for shareability before being included in the evidence file: one passage in the source notes named a specific member’s decision regarding the box house program; that passage has been generalized to preserve the substantive fact (member-level decisions shifted away from box house) without embedding any single investor’s personal participation posture. Other named attributions reflect meeting-attribution discipline, which is preserved.

Numbers are recorded verbatim from the source — dollar amounts, percentages, hour-budget figures, statutory thresholds, and the cash-flow illustration Andy explicitly characterized as “rough, off-the-cuff” are reproduced with their original approximation language (“approximately,” “roughly,” “~”). They have not been promoted to false precision.

A correction entry to these minutes will be written if (a) a participant in the meeting identifies a substantive misattribution, (b) the meeting recording reveals that the source narrative materially mis-summarized a passage, (c) Andy Martin or another Liberty representative subsequently corrects any figure or framing, or (d) any policy citation (Liberty’s underwriting tests, Equipment Share’s prospectus language about the own program, EZ’s hurdle-rate posture) is found to be inaccurate. Corrections will be additive; this version of the minutes will not be overwritten.

These minutes are a contemporaneous working record, not a verbatim transcript, not legal or tax advice, and not a substitute for professional opinion. They are intended for inclusion in the audit-defense evidence file for participants in the EquipmentShare / EZ Equipment Zone Advantage Flex heavy machinery rental program and are paired downstream with material-participation journal entries documenting individual investor participation where applicable.

*Authored: 2026-05-17. Source: Draft meeting summary 2026-03-20-Liberty-FCU__joss-renaud.-DRAFT_MTG_NOTES.pdf. System prompt: **Audit-Defensible Meeting Minutes Generator** (companion to the Material Participation Journal Entry Generator).*